

The Mishna in תענית (4:8) says, *זה מתן תורה*, *זה מתן תורה* - referring to the *יום טוב* of *שבועות*, of *מתן תורה*. R' Moshe Wolfson, in a marvelous *sefer* called *Festivals of Faith*, which discusses *פסח*, *שבועות*, and the summer months, has a beautiful essay on the phrase *זה מתן תורה*, *זה מתן תורה* - the day of the wedding. What is this wedding? It's the *חתן* and *כלה* of *שיר השירים*. He mentions a fascinating *מדרש* based on a *pasuk* in *מלכים א' (ה:י"ב)*, describing the vastness of *שלמה המלך*'s wisdom. The *נביא* says, *וַיְדַבֵּר שְׁלֹשֶׁת אֲלָפִים מָשָׁל* - he spoke 3,000 *משלים*. So what if *שלמה המלך* was able to come up with 3,000 *משלים*? The *Dubno Maggid* might have had almost as many, if not more. What is the *pasuk* really telling us?

The *נביא* isn't just saying that *שלמה המלך* came up with a lot of *משלים*. He's describing a chain of 3,000 *משלים*. *שלמה המלך* understood the core truth and essence of the *מציאות* of *עולם הזה*, and he wanted to share that concept with the rest of us. But that idea was so lofty, so far beyond what the average person could grasp, that he had to express it in a *משל*. He gave one *משל*, but it was still too abstract. So he gave a second *משל*. Still too difficult. A third *משל*, a fourth *משל*, and he kept going, lowering it, making it more concrete, more relatable. When he reached the 3,000th *משל*, then the people understood. What was that 3,000th *משל*? That was *שיר השירים*. It describes the union between *הקדוש ברוך הוא* and *כלל ישראל*. That union came into being on *שבועות*. Until then, *עולם הבא* and *שמים* were always above, and we were down here in *עולם הזה*. But on the sixth day of *sivan*, *וַיֵּרֶד ה' עַל הָר סִינִי (שמות י"ט:כ')*. And at the same time, *וַאֲל מִשְׁה אָמַר עֲלֶה אֵל*. The joining of *עולם הבא* and *עולם הזה*.

*מתן תורה* is clearly understood as a *חתונה*. It's not that *הר סיני* is like a *חתונה*. Rather, we model our *חתונות*, our *חתנים* and *כלות*, based on what happened at *הר סיני*. Interestingly, many have a *מנהג* that the *חתן* starts to walk towards the *כלה* when she comes down the aisle, like *Hashem* came down towards the people. The candles that are carried by those walking the *חתן* and *כלה* remind us of the flashes of lightning. The *חופה* above is like the mountain that *Hashem* lifted over their heads. A *חתן* designates his *כלה* with *קידושין* as *Hashem* chose us as His nation. Later on, the *לווחות*, which serve as the *שטר קידושין*, are also two - corresponding to the *חתן* and *כלה*. They were placed in the holiest place on earth, the *קדש הקדשים*, where the two *כרובים* stood, representing the cosmic couple.

What a gigantic, beautiful *משל* and a new take on what *שבועות* is all about. *Hashem* finished the creation, finished the *בריאה*, with *שבועות*. That's where the *בריאה* found its *מנוחה*, its tranquility and calm, because the *בריאה* had finally arrived at its purpose. The *חתן* and *כלה* were here. We are that *חתן* and *כלה*. We have to appreciate the magnificence and the majesty of *הר סיני*. Yes, we know that *כפה עליהם הר כגיגית*. We know there was lightning and thunder. We know that there were *עננים*. We know that *כלל ישראל* died hearing the voice of *Hashem*. But the great *גדולים* of the past, and not even that long ago, the great *chassidish gedolim* and even the *litvish gedolim*, had an exceptional feeling for the majesty and the awesomeness of *הר סיני*. If we just get a little glimpse of that from this little *משל*, I think it will have been worth the time I spent relaying it to you.

